

HOW TO SUCCEED WHEN YOU HAVE BEEN REJECTED

Blue denotes power point slide

Brown denotes instructions to technician

TEXT: Genesis 37:3-4 (NKJV) *“Now Israel loved Joseph more than all his children, because he was the son of his old age. Also he made him a tunic of many colors. ⁴But when his brothers saw that their father loved him more than all his brothers, they hated him and could not speak peaceably to him.”*

Genesis 45:3-8 (NKJV) *“Then Joseph said to his brothers, “I am Joseph; does my father still live?” But his brothers could not answer him, for they were dismayed in his presence. ⁴And Joseph said to his brothers, “Please come near to me.” So they came near. Then he said: “I am Joseph your brother, whom you sold into Egypt. ⁵“But now, do not therefore be grieved or angry with yourselves because you sold me here; for God sent me before you to preserve life. ⁶“For these two years the famine has been in the land, and there are still five years in which there will be neither plowing nor harvesting. ⁷“And God sent me before you to preserve a posterity for you in the earth, and to save your lives by a great deliverance.”*

INTRO: We live in a world of rejection; individuals are being rejected in the following ways: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Spouses are rejected by their companions...

- Children feel the rejection of divorce...
- Business people are rejected by partners and clients...
- Friends are rejected and betrayed despite life-long relationships...
- Corporations terminate employees who have given their best years to build the company...
- Citizens are rejected by politicians who have their own best interest at heart, rather than the good of the people...

The list could continue on into infinity. The world has a way of bruising and battering its inhabitants. Sin is the primary cause of all rejection. **Selfishness is the root of all sin.**

Though the world beats up its populace, Jesus stands ready to heal all broken hearts. **Luke 4:18-19 (NKJV) *“The Spirit of the LORD is upon Me, Because He has anointed Me To preach the gospel to the poor; He has sent Me to heal the brokenhearted, To proclaim liberty to the captives And recovery of sight to the blind, To set at liberty those who are oppressed; ¹⁹ To proclaim the acceptable year of the LORD.”***

In order to get a handle on a plan for recovering from rejection, I want us to look at a Biblical character who suffered rejection at every level. Over the next couple of weeks we are going to do an in depth study of the life of Joseph. I love the story of the life of **Joseph** because it **is a perfect example of a life marked and**

marred by adversity, yet, despite the problematic path, the grace of God is shown through a life of integrity.

Though Joseph was born with a silver spoon in his mouth, the real Joseph is placed on display when crisis after crisis attempts to keep him from all God intended him to be.

Look at a snapshot of Joseph's life:

- Joseph was the son of Jacob and Rachel...
- At the age of seventeen he is tending the flock of Jacob, his Father...
- Joseph was the favorite child of his father because he was the child of his old age...
- Because of parental partiality, he was hated by his brothers... (Coat of Many Colors)
- He began to dream dreams of exaltation, such as the dream of binding sheaves and the sheaves of his brothers bowing down to him; the sun, the moon, and eleven stars making obeisance to him...
- Because of his dreams, his brother's dislike for him turned to hatred...
- Joseph's brothers conspire to kill him, but Reuben says, ***"Let's put him in a pit and leave him there,"*** thinking he would come later and deliver Joseph unto his father...
- His brothers took his Coat of many Colors and dipped it in blood, deliver it unto Jacob, his father, and allowed him to believe a wild beast killed Joseph... (His brothers actually sold him to the Midianites)

- The Midianite Merchantmen sold him to the Ishmeelites for 20 pieces of silver...
- The Ishmeelites sold Joseph to Potiphar, an officer of Pharaoh...
- Potiphar recognizes the Lord is with Joseph, because everything Joseph touches becomes a success...
- Potiphar makes Joseph the Business Manager of his entire fortune...
- God prospers Joseph as the business manager of Potiphar, as a result, his master realizes some very hefty profits...
- The wife of Potiphar tries unsuccessfully to seduce Joseph... Notice the words of Joseph when faced with such a tantalizing temptation, ***“I refuse to commit this sin against my God.”***
- When the wife of Potiphar sees that Joseph is a young man of integrity and will not commit adultery with her, she lies to Potiphar and Joseph is put in prison...
- Joseph is made overseer of all the prisoners...
- While Joseph is in prison, Pharaoh’s butler and baker become inmates...
- The butler and baker both dream dreams and Joseph interprets them upon the condition that when the butler is restored, he will tell the king of Joseph’s injustice...
- Just as Joseph predicts, the butler is restored to the King’s favor and the baker is hanged...
- Two years pass before the butler makes good on his promise to Joseph...

- Pharaoh dreams a dream that no one could interpret. This dream was of seven fat cattle coming up out of the river and then seven poor cattle coming up out of the river. The seven poor cattle ate up the seven fat cattle. Then he dreamed again and seven fat ears of corn sprang up on one stalk and seven thin ears of corn on another stalk blasted by the east wind. The seven thin ears ate up the seven fat ears. Pharaoh had a nightmare...
- Pharaoh's butler says, "***I know someone who can interpret this dream.***" The butler makes good on his promise to Joseph...
- Joseph interprets Pharaoh's dream of seven years of plenty and seven years of famine...
- Joseph is made second-in-command in Egypt...

Remember, about fourteen years have transpired since Joseph was sold into Egypt. The path he was called upon to travel to the palace was not Easy Street!

Everyone who is great for God has traveled a path which is strewn with havoc, rejection and difficulty.

Look at the Heroes of the faith: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Abel's faith cost him his life, but his blood spoke from the ground...
- Enoch's faith caused him to walk with God... Anyone who walks with God will be hated by the world!
- Noah's faith caused him to build an Ark in a climate where it had never rained before...

- Abraham's faith caused him to leave his homeland and offer his son Isaac on the altar of sacrifice...
- Moses' faith caused him to defy Pharaoh and lead the Children of Israel to the Promised Land...
- Paul's faith landed him in jail...

Listen to this; [Hebrews 11:32-40](#) (NKJV) *“And what more shall I say? For the time would fail me to tell of Gideon and Barak and Samson and Jephthah, also of David and Samuel and the prophets: ³³who through faith subdued kingdoms, worked righteousness, obtained promises, stopped the mouths of lions, ³⁴quenched the violence of fire, escaped the edge of the sword, out of weakness were made strong, became valiant in battle, turned to flight the armies of the aliens. ³⁵Women received their dead raised to life again. And others were tortured, not accepting deliverance, that they might obtain a better resurrection. ³⁶Still others had trial of mockings and scourgings, yes, and of chains and imprisonment. ³⁷They were stoned, they were sawn in two, were tempted, were slain with the sword. They wandered about in sheepskins and goatskins, being destitute, afflicted, tormented— ³⁸of whom the world was not worthy. They wandered in deserts and mountains, in dens and caves of the earth. ³⁹And all these, having obtained a good testimony through faith, did not receive the promise, ⁴⁰God having provided something better for us, that they should not be made perfect apart from us.”*

(END OF SERMON #1)

I. FORGIVENESS IS ESSENTIAL TO OVERCOMING REJECTION...

In Bible days, people named their children for something of significance in their life. When Joseph's first child was born he named him Manasseh.

Manasseh means "causing to forget or forgetfulness."

Notice vs. 51 ***"And Joseph called the name of the firstborn Manasseh: For God, said he hath made me forget all my toil, and all my father's house."***

What is Joseph saying here?

- Is he saying God has removed his mother, father and eleven brothers from his memory? No!
- Is he saying God has erased the maltreatment by his siblings from his memory? No!
- Is he saying God has stricken the rejection by his brothers from his memory? No!

He is simply saying that God has taken the pain out of a past experience for Him. If anyone has ever had a reason to be bitter and have a critical attitude, surely Joseph did.

How could a guy who had been through what Joseph had endured ever be able to get past the pain? The path to peace in Joseph's life is really pretty simple. When his first son was born, he named him Manasseh meaning, ***"The Lord hath made me to forget."*** While Joseph could not forget his father, mother and eleven brothers, what he could do was to forgive them, and that he did!

Have you ever been wronged? Been rejected?
Treated badly? Been double crossed? Cheated out of
something? These things can bring with them a boat
load of pain; how we react to these things will define
who we are! If we forgive, we can move on with our
life and become who God intended us to be. If we
withhold forgiveness, we immediately become stunted
in our growth pattern and slowly but surely become
critical if not downright bitter!

Many have critical spirits, who call themselves
Christians. Why are they critical? Because they have
never come to a place of letting God take the pain out
of a past experience. Past experiences are why some
people don't serve God today. If we allow past
experiences to stand between us and serving God, we
will lose out with God and our lives will be less than
they were intended to be.

Most people fail to forgive, hoping to inflict pain on
the un-forgiven individual when in reality **the person
who is withholding forgiveness places themselves in a
prison for a life term or until forgiveness can be
dispensed.**

I don't know what you have been going through but if
Joseph could endure all this, and forget the past, surely
you and I can forget the past and serve God
victoriously!

**Keys to victory: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE
AT A TIME)**

- Allow God to take the pain out of a past experience... Paul, who had everything happen to him except his life being taken from him says in [Philippians 3:13-14](#) (NKJV) ***“Brethren, I do not count myself to have apprehended; but one thing I do, forgetting those things which are behind and reaching forward to those things which are ahead,** ¹⁴*I press toward the goal for the prize of the upward call of God in Christ Jesus.”* How in the world is it possible to allow God to take the pain out of a past experience for us? First of all we must forgive! While teaching His disciples how to pray, Jesus makes this statement, [Matthew 6:12](#) (NKJV) ***“And forgive us our debts, As we forgive our debtors.”*** If that is not enough, following “The Lord’s Prayer” He says to His disciples, almost as an afterthought, [Matthew 6:14-15](#) (NKJV) ***“For if you forgive men their trespasses, your heavenly Father will also forgive you.”** ¹⁵***“But if you do not forgive men their trespasses, neither will your Father forgive your trespasses.”*** How is this kind of forgiveness possible? The Bible tells us that God has ***“Taken our sins and cast them as far as the East is from the West never to be remembered against us again.”*** Think of what Christ did for us upon the cross of Calvary. Now think of all the times we have sinned against Him. As soon as we asked to be forgiven, He forgave us and forgot it, pure and simple! If He has done all of this for us, then we cannot withhold forgiveness from our brethren. (Ex. Parable of man who owed his**

master much, the debt was forgiven, and then he turned around and did not forgive a little debt owed to him.) Many people are just that way. Not only must we forgive, but if we think your brother or sister has a problem with us, we are responsible to go to that person and straighten things out. [Matthew 5:23-24](#) (NKJV)

“Therefore if you bring your gift to the altar, and there remember that your brother has something against you, ²⁴“leave your gift there before the altar, and go your way. First be reconciled to your brother, and then come and offer your gift.”

A lack of forgiveness is the very reason many Christians never mature, they have never learned to forgive. A good exercise for forgiveness is to write a letter of forgiveness... Make a phone call of forgiveness...

- [Live in the present and the future and minimize the failures of the past... Philippians 3:13-14](#) (NKJV) ***“Brethren, I do not count myself to have apprehended; but one thing I do, forgetting those things which are behind and reaching forward to those things which are ahead, ¹⁴I press toward the goal for the prize of the upward call of God in Christ Jesus.”*** Un-forgiveness requires a lot of energy and attention. If we channel this energy and attention toward what is happening today and tomorrow we will not have what it takes to keep holding to the past!
- [Do good deeds to those who have wronged us... Matthew 5:43-45](#) (NKJV) ***“You have heard that***

it was said, 'You shall love your neighbor and hate your enemy.' ⁴⁴"But I say to you, love your enemies, bless those who curse you, do good to those who hate you, and pray for those who spitefully use you and persecute you, ⁴⁵"that you may be sons of your Father in heaven; for He makes His sun rise on the evil and on the good, and sends rain on the just and on the unjust." That's a tall order, so how

do we do this? Paul told the Philippian Christians, [Philippians 4:8](#) (NKJV) *"Finally, brethren, whatever things are true, whatever things are noble, whatever things are just, whatever things are pure, whatever things are lovely, whatever things are of good report, if there is any virtue and if there is anything praiseworthy—meditate on these things."*

When we begin to allow God's Word to do its work in us we do not have to do God's work for Him, He will manifest His miracles through us! [We must allow our minds to be ridded of past failures, defeats, and wrongs, by dwelling on good things, forgetting the past, and dwelling on the future!](#)

We see a perfect example of these things being pressed into service in the life of Joseph. Joseph's 10 brothers came to buy corn in Egypt at the command of their father Jacob. Joseph had the authority and the motive to kill every one of them but notice what he did. He gives them their corn, and puts their money back in their sacks. He keeps Simeon so that they will bring Benjamin back with them.

As a last resort, Jacob consents to let Benjamin come with them. Joseph makes a feast for them, gives them corn and supplies, and once again puts their money back in their sacks, only this time he puts his silver cup in Benjamin's sack and lets them go. When they are gone, he sends his servants after them and his servants find the cup in Benjamin's sack. Joseph's brothers plead with him, not knowing with whom they were pleading then he reveals who he is. His brothers are afraid for their lives.

Listen to the words of Joseph when his brothers realize who they are dealing with. [Genesis 45:4-8](#) (NKJV)

“And Joseph said to his brothers, “Please come near to me.” So they came near. Then he said: “I am Joseph your brother, whom you sold into Egypt.

⁵“But now, do not therefore be grieved or angry with yourselves because you sold me here; for God sent me before you to preserve life. ***⁶“For these two years the famine has been in the land, and there are still five years in which there will be neither plowing nor harvesting. ⁷“And God sent me before you to preserve a posterity for you in the earth, and to save your lives by a great deliverance.*** ***⁸“So now it was not you who sent me here, but God; and He has made me a father to Pharaoh, and lord of all his house, and a ruler throughout all the land of Egypt.”***

The reason Joseph could deal with his brothers so gently when they came to buy corn in Egypt is because he forgave them long before they arrived! Why? Because ***“Manasseh, the Lord hath made me to***

forget!” He named his son Manasseh so that each time he spoke his son’s name, he was reminded to keep forgiving his brothers. *As Joseph forgave his brothers he was releasing his own family from the shackles of the curse of un-forgiveness!*

This very same thing can happen to you! I don’t know about you, but I believe there were probably days when the past would begin to bother him and all he had to do was to look at Manasseh and that was enough to cause him to forget the past.

II. FRUITFULNESS; THE RESULT OF FORGIVENESS...

Joseph named his second son Ephraim. *Genesis 41:52*

“And the name of the second he called Ephraim:

‘For God has caused me to be fruitful in the land of my affliction.’” The name *Ephraim* means *“Double Fruit.”*

Remember, Joseph named his first son Manasseh because God had taken the pain out of a past experience for him. Joseph’s ability to forgive is absolutely unquestioned. Now his second son comes along and he chooses an equally important and significant name by naming him Ephraim.

There are *three things which I want us to focus on:*

(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- God caused Joseph to be fruitful...
- God caused Joseph to be fruitful in the land of his affliction...
- Joseph never lost sight of the fact that Egypt was not his home...

1) Why did God cause Joseph to be fruitful? Because he was a man of integrity and he demonstrated an ability not to allow his past to dictate the present and the future.

Far too many times we allow our past to determine where we are today and where we are going in all of our tomorrows. Be assured, if we cannot get past a prior failure or injury we cannot succeed today or tomorrow.

Joseph makes a declaration which flies in the face of everything we know; ***“God has caused me to be fruitful....”*** Joseph should have been a bitter failure rotting in a jail cell but he informs us that God has allowed fruitfulness in his life despite past failures and setbacks.

This is great for Joseph but how can I bring this about in my life? Live a life of integrity and forgive everyone who commits an offense against us! The level of our integrity and ability to forgive is directly tied to the level of the success we can achieve in our lives! Philippians 3:13-14 (NKJV) ***“Brethren, I do not count myself to have apprehended; but one thing I do, forgetting those things which are behind and reaching forward to those things which are ahead, ¹⁴I press toward the goal for the prize of the upward call of God in Christ Jesus.”***

2) Joseph does not stop with the words ***“God has caused me to be fruitful...”*** If he had stopped there this would still be an amazing story on how to succeed

when we have been rejected. Listen to the entire statement, ***“God has caused me to be fruitful in the land of my affliction.”***

Anyone can be successful when everything is going right but it takes something special to succeed when all things are against you.

Everything was against Joseph: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- He was hated by his brothers...
- He was sold as an Egyptian slave...
- He was falsely accused of sexual assault...
- He was falsely imprisoned in a foreign land...
- He was estranged from everyone who could help him...

In spite of all of this he became the Prime Minister of Egypt, with all the benefits of such an office. He was an extremely powerful and wealthy man.

I can only imagine what the wife of Potiphar must have thought when she discovered Joseph was now the Prime Minister. I can only imagine what Joseph's brothers must have thought when they discovered the little brat they sold into Egyptian slavery is now the Prime Minister!

Most of us would have dealt with the wicked witch of the east at the first opportunity possible. We would have chastised or killed the people who sent us to Egypt, but Joseph never even considers such a thing, which is precisely why God could place him in such a

position of authority and bless him with unbelievable wealth.

God will only give us what he can trust us with!

3) Joseph never lost sight of the fact that Egypt was not home for him; ***“God has caused me to be fruitful in the land of my affliction.”***

Joseph lived in the land of affliction but he walked uprightly before God. Because he walked uprightly before God, God blessed Joseph in many ways:

(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- He was blessed with Divine protection...
- He was blessed with Divine direction...
- He was blessed with positions of influence...
- He was blessed with a family who honored God...
- He was blessed in his finances...

Ephraim means *“Double Fruit.”* Every time the name Ephraim was formed on the lips of Joseph, this man of God was reminded that his success was not his own but success which had been given to him by the God he served.

Far too many of us get our sights set on what this world can offer. Earth is not home for the Christian; at its very best it is the land of our affliction! 2 Peter 2:11-12 (CEV) ***“Dear friends, you are foreigners and strangers on this earth. So I beg you not to surrender to those desires that fight against you.*** ¹² *Always let others see you behaving properly, even though they*

may still accuse you of doing wrong. Then on the day of judgment, they will honor God by telling the good things they saw you do.” 1 Peter 1:17-19 (CEV) “... you must honor God while you live as strangers here on earth. ¹⁸ You were rescued from the useless way of life that you learned from your ancestors. But you know that you were not rescued by such things as silver or gold that don’t last forever. ¹⁹ You were rescued by the precious blood of Christ, that spotless and innocent lamb.”

While Joseph was able to achieve unbelievable success in the land of his affliction he never allowed himself to take his focus off of the fact that he was an Israelite and Jehovah had a better plan than Egypt for him and his descendants. [Genesis 50:20-25 \(NKJV\)](#) “*So Joseph dwelt in Egypt, he and his father’s household. And Joseph lived one hundred and ten years. ²³ Joseph saw Ephraim’s children to the third generation. The children of Machir, the son of Manasseh, were also brought up on Joseph’s knees. ²⁴ And Joseph said to his brethren, “I am dying; but God will surely visit you, and bring you out of this land to the land of which He swore to Abraham, to Isaac, and to Jacob.” ²⁵ Then Joseph took an oath from the children of Israel, saying, “God will surely visit you, and you shall carry up my bones from here.” ²⁶ So Joseph died, being one hundred and ten years old; and they embalmed him, and he was put in a coffin in Egypt.”*

No matter how much wealth, notoriety, or success we achieve here, [we must keep our eyes on the fact that](#)

this earth is not home for us! 1 Thessalonians 4:13-17

(NKJV) *“But I do not want you to be ignorant, brethren, concerning those who have fallen asleep, lest you sorrow as others who have no hope. ¹⁴For if we believe that Jesus died and rose again, even so God will bring with Him those who sleep in Jesus. ¹⁵For this we say to you by the word of the Lord, that we who are alive and remain until the coming of the Lord will by no means precede those who are asleep. ¹⁶For the Lord Himself will descend from heaven with a shout, with the voice of an archangel, and with the trumpet of God. And the dead in Christ will rise first. ¹⁷Then we who are alive and remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air. And thus we shall always be with the Lord. ¹⁸Therefore comfort one another with these words.”*

1 Corinthians 15:51-57 (NKJV) *“Behold, I tell you a mystery: We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed— ⁵²in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trumpet. For the trumpet will sound, and the dead will be raised incorruptible, and we shall be changed. ⁵³For this corruptible must put on incorruption, and this mortal must put on immortality. ⁵⁴So when this corruptible has put on incorruption, and this mortal has put on immortality, then shall be brought to pass the saying that is written: “Death is swallowed up in victory.” ⁵⁵“O Death, where is your sting? O Hades, where is your victory?” ⁵⁶The sting of death is sin, and the strength of sin is the law. ⁵⁷But thanks be to God, who gives us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ.*

⁵⁸*Therefore, my beloved brethren, be steadfast,
immovable, always abounding in the work of the
Lord, knowing that your labor is not in vain in the
Lord.”*